Behind The Mask: Director of Pharmacy of Specialty Infusion Services (Oncology) Career Guide 💊

From Episode 3: The Pharmacist's Perspective with **Mariana Szpakowski, PharmD**

What is this career?
Definition: A pharmacy leader who oversees medication-related services, pharmacy operations, and medication safety across specialty infusion centers. In oncology, pharmacists work with oncologists, nurses, and other healthcare professionals to help ensure patients receive appropriate and safe medication treatments.

What do they do?
"I am responsible for taking care of 11 infusion centers all across New Jersey. So, I do a lot of regimen building. We focus on oncology patients who have cancer, and patients who have hematology disorders like iron deficiency and other factors. And we also do something called specialty infusion where patients may have multiple sclerosis, patients who have rheumatological conditions, gastrointestinal issues like Crohn's disease or ulcerative colitis, or may have some forms of asthma where they need injections or IVs. So I collaborate with a lot of these referring specialists and doctors to make sure that their patients have access to medications and their infusions, so we can safely give these medications to these patients.**"**

Education pathway (Mariana's pathway!)
"So I first did my undergrad. I went to Fairleigh Dickinson University, and I majored in chemistry. And I also did some classes in biology because I knew if you wanted to go to grad school, there were certain prerequisites that are required to get in. So even though I majored in chemistry, I would take a look at whatever grad school you wanna go to, what profession you wanna go into, and make sure that whatever you're doing for your undergrad kind of coincides and aligns with what you need for pre-reqs to complete for grad school. 'Cause that way you won't be spending more time in your undergrad to get to where you wanna get to for grad. So then I ended up doing four years of undergrad, then I worked one year in a chemical lab to save money. Then, I went back, and that's when the first inaugural class of the Fairleigh Dickinson University School of Pharmacy opened up. So when they opened up, I was the first class, and I did dual. So I did my PharmD with my master's at the same time, so throughout the four-year program. So I did four years undergrad, four years of my dual with my master's and my PharmD at the same time. So eight years of schooling."

Licensures/certifications
Required:

- Doctor of Pharmacy (PharmD)
- State Pharmacist License
- **Optional: Board Certification Oncology Pharmacist (BCOP) and Postgraduate Pharmacy Residency

Skills needed

- Leadership & Team Management

- Communication, Problem-Solving & Critical Thinking
- Attention to Detail
- Financial & Budget Management
- Organization & Multitasking
- Adaptability

Challenges faced
"I feel like the most challenging part is, especially when you're starting out in any field, it's confidence. Because you may have learned so much in school, but now applying it in real life is so challenging because it's not everything by the book. What you learn is what you apply. So you need to be able to build that confidence and be able to know how to research things and which guidelines to use. And, you know, we are so big on evidence-based medicine, which means it's not what this person did because they just did it to treat. We look at literature, clinical trials, we evaluate, we read, and healthcare is never-ending studying and learning. So it's challenging because what you may have known yesterday may be completely different from what you know today or tomorrow, 'cause guidelines are constantly changing, so you have to make sure you keep up with what's happening every day."

Career progression ability
Entry-Level Pharmacist → Oncology Pharmacist → ***optional** Board-Certified Oncology Pharmacist (BCOP) → Oncology Pharmacy Coordinator/Manager → Director of Pharmacy or Oncology Pharmacy Services

Related careers
1. *Medical Oncologist* - treats cancer using medications and other therapies
2. *Oncology Nurse* - provides hands-on care to patients throughout cancer treatment
3. *Clinical Research Coordinator* - manages clinical trials of new cancer treatments
4. *Pharmaceutical Scientist* - researches and develops new medications
5. *Radiation Therapist* - delivers radiation treatments to cancer patients

Advice from Mariana
"Go for it. Go for it, and do not give up. Go for your dreams and do it for yourself. Do it for wanting to help other people. That is the biggest takeaway I can give anyone, and when you go through your undergrad and grad, you're gonna think, "Oh, my gosh, did I make the right choice? This is so hard. I'm losing sleep." It's all worth it in the end, I promise. And you will meet so many people down the road, and there's a reason why you met them. There's a reason why every single person comes into your life. It may be a few minutes, or you can know them for many years, but go for it and trust your gut and your instinct, 'cause you guys will do awesome."

Podcast episode
Season 2, Episode 3: **The Pharmacist's Perspective with Mariana Szpakowski, PharmD**